



Cool cacti



Long, yellow spines erupt in starry clusters from ridges on the body.

Vertical stems can grow up to 26 ft (8 m) tall.

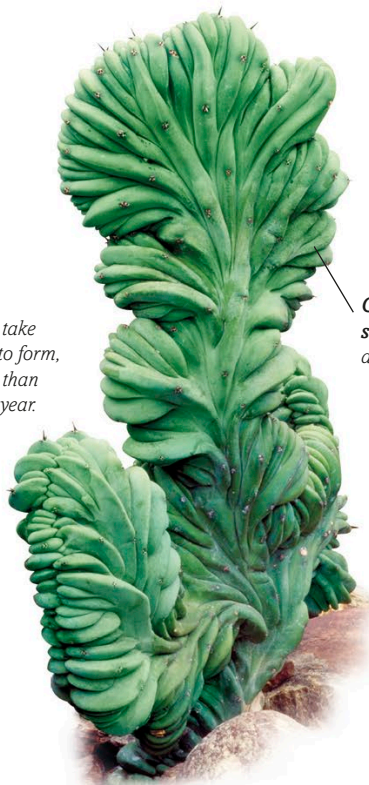
Organ pipe cactus



Overlapping stems create a fan shape.

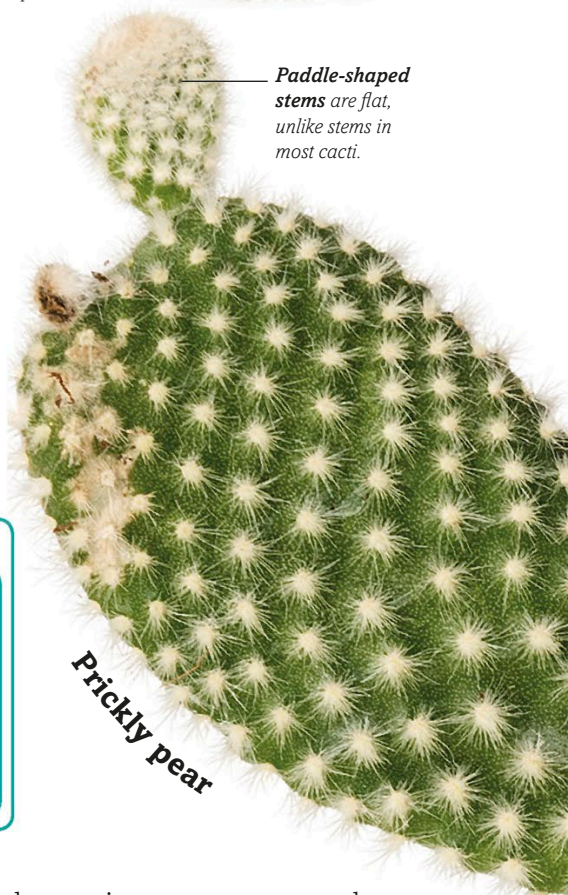
Barrel cactus

Branches can take up to 40 years to form, growing at less than 1 in (2.5 cm) a year.



Bilberry cactus

Paddle-shaped stems are flat, unlike stems in most cacti.



Prickly pear

Saguaro



Birds such as this owl use the saguaro cactus for nesting.



TALLEST CACTUS

With a recorded height of 63 ft (19.2 m) and a trunk about 3 ft (1 m) thick, the Mexican false saguaro is the tallest-known living cactus in the world.



63 ft (19.2 m)

Many cacti live in the desert, where their water-filled stems help them survive long periods of drought. Most plants use their leaves to make food from sunlight, but cacti do this using their green, fleshy stems. To protect themselves from hungry animals, cacti have specially adapted leaves called spines.

Living in hot and dry environments means that cacti have to make the most of the rare, but often heavy, rainfall. Ribs on the **barrel cactus** allow it to stretch its stem to quickly take in as much water as possible. In harsh desert conditions, plants grow very slowly and live a long time. Some, such as the **saguaro** and **false saguaro cacti**, can live for up to 300 years. These tall